coursera | MoMA

Seeing Through Photographs ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs
- ✓ Welcome to Seeing Through Photographs! Reading • 3 min
- ✓ Getting Started: How Does This Course Work? Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Seeing Through Photographs Course Trailer Video • 1 min
- ✓ Sarah Meister Introduces the Course Video • 2 min
- ✓ Marvin Heiferman on "Photography Changes Everything" Video • 3 min
- ✓ Optional Discussion Forum Prompts Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Optional Readings and Resources Reading • 10 min

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 1 Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Artistic Equivalents Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Vik Muniz on Photographing the Familiar Video • 3 min

Part II: Telescopes and Cameras
- ✓ Introduction to Part II: Surface, Scale, and Technology Video • 2 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Moons and Surfaces Reading • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Eugène Atget. Pendant l'éclipse. 1912 Video • 3 min
- ✓ Hear More: Liz Deschenes on Tilt/Swing (360° field of vision, version 1), 2009 Video • 1 min
- ✓ Surface, Scale, Technology Dialogue • 15 min

Part III: Seeing the Unseen
- ✓ Introduction to Part III: Man on the Moon Video • 2 min
- ✓ Photographs by NASA Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on U.S.G.S. and NASA, Surveyor III. Surface of the Moon, Day 319, III-F. 1967 Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ **Who Does the Moon Belong To?** Reading • 4 min

Part IV: It's Only a Paper Moon
- ○ Introduction to Part IV: Vernacular and Fine Art Photographs of the Moon Video • 3 min
- ○ Moon Phases Reading • 6 min
- ○ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Ansel Adams. Moonrise, Hernandez, New Mexico. 1941 Video • 3 min
- ○ Man on the Moon and Paper Moons Dialogue • 15 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ○ Optional Readings and Resources Reading • 10 min
- ○ Practice Memory Check Practice Assignment • 30 min
- ○ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Module 4
One and Another

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

Who Does the Moon Belong To?

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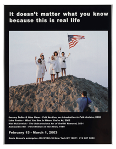
Aleksandra Mir


it doesn't matter what you know because this is real life
Jeremy Deller & Alan Kane - Folk Archive, an introduction to Folk Archive, 2003
Luke Fowler - What You See is Where You're At, 2002
Mat McCormick - The Subconscious Art of Graffiti Removal, 2001
Aleksandra Mir - First Woman on the Moon, 1999
February 15 - March 1, 2003
Gavin Brown's enterprise 436 W15th St New York NY 10011 212 627 5258

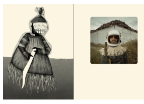
Aleksandra Mir. *First Woman on the Moon at Gavin Brown's enterprise, New York, February 15–March 1, 2003*. 2003. Invitation flyer, sheet, 11 × 8 1/2" (27.9 × 21.6 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Richard Gerrig and Timothy Peterson. © 2020 Aleksandra Mir

Images like those produced by NASA cultivated the narrative that space exploration was a uniquely male venture. In response, Aleksandra Mir staged a performance in August 1999, almost exactly thirty years after Neil Armstrong's walk on the moon. According to the artist, "heavy machinery and manpower transformed a Dutch beach into a lunar landscape of hills and craters" over the course of a day. At sunset, Mir climbed the highest peak and planted an American flag in the sand before proclaiming herself the "first woman on the moon."

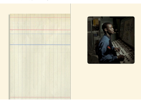
Mir documented this performance using film and photography. This flyer promoted an exhibition of the work with the tagline "It doesn't matter what you know because this is real life"—a playful nod toward the conspiracy theory that the Apollo 11 landing was staged in a Hollywood Studio.

Watch **Aleksandra Mir's performance**

Cristina de Middel



Cristina de Middel. *The Afronauts*. 2012. Artist's book, 11.8 × 16.6" (30 × 42.2 cm) spread; 11.8 × 8.3" (30 × 21 cm) closed. Publisher: Cristina de Middel, Cadiz, Spain. Courtesy the artist. © 2020 Cristina de Middel



Cristina de Middel. *The Afronauts*. 2012. Artist's book, 11.8 × 16.6" (30 × 42.2 cm) spread; 11.8 × 8.3" (30 × 21 cm) closed. Publisher: Cristina de Middel, Cadiz, Spain. Courtesy the artist. © 2020 Cristina de Middel

In 1964, Zambia gained its independence from the United Kingdom. That same year, Edward Mukaka Nkoloso, a science teacher and member of the Zambian resistance movement, became the founding director of the Zambia National Academy of Science, Space Research, and Philosophy. His goal was for Zambia to enter the space race and send a 17-year-old girl and two cats to the moon. He also began making plans for a trip to Mars, which would have made Zambia the first country to visit the planet. In an article in the *Lusaka Times*, Nkoloso wrote: "We have been studying the planet through telescopes at our headquarters and are now certain Mars is populated by primitive natives. Our rocket crew is ready…and a missionary will be launched in our first rocket. But I have warned the missionary he must not force Christianity on the people in Mars if they do not want it." To this day, the sincerity of Nkoloso's mission is debated, with many interpreting his work and writings as a critique of Western imperialism and the colonization of Africa.

While the mission of Zambian space exploration was never fully realized, the story served as inspiration for Cristina de Middel's series, *The Afronauts*. Hiring African actors based in her home country of Spain, de Middel dressed them in spacesuits made from African fabrics and asked them to pose in rocky landscapes and artificial studios. These staged photographs are paired with altered archival images that display moonsuited figures in the middle of African villages, prompting us to question their relationship to reality.

The Afronauts draws attention to the imperial gaze directed at outer space, making visible the ways in which the moon has often been depicted as a "final frontier," a territory for Western nations to colonize.

Watch **Cristina de Middel's short film based on the project**

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